BRASS TACKS

ICANT POLITICAL INFLUENCE



GENERAL QAMAR JAVED BAJWA
(2016–2022)

Bajwa promoted a vision of "geo-economics over geopolitics", advocating stability and economic growth. But he resorted to political engineering, influencing elections, judiciary and media, thus damaging the army's credibility. His peace moves with India (2021 LoC ceasefire) and Gulf outreach were seen as pluses.



GENERAL ASIM MUNIR
(2022–)

Asim Munir reasserted army dominance after facing defiance from Imran Khan and his supporters. His vision of Pakistan is that of a 'hard state' that is militarised and centralised, as he deals with its multiple crises. He inserted the army formally into economic management. He promotes a moderate Islamic nationalism and is seen as markedly anti-India.

MUNIR HAS EMERGED AS ONE OF THE MOST POWERFUL ARMY CHIEFS OF PAKISTAN WITHOUT HAVING TO TOPPLE THE CIVILIAN DISPENSATION

rare distinction of being a Hafiz-e-Quran, or someone who has memorised the holy book by heart, passing the test when he was posted as the army's attaché in Saudi Arabia. It was a trait he picked up from his father, Syed Sarwar, who had migrated from Jalandhar after Partition. A schoolteacher in Rawalpindi, Sarwar also delivered the Friday sermon at a local mosque.

Munir himself studied in a madrassa in the garrison town before winning a commission in the army through the Officers Training School (OTS) route rather than the more prestigious Pakistan Military Academy. But that didn't stop his meteoric if turbulent rise to the top echelons of the army. Rana Banerjee, a former special secretary of the Research and Analysis Wing (RAW), India's external intelligence agency, and an expert on Pakistan, says, "Munir's first name, Asim, means the great saviour, and the army chief seems driven by a deep sense of religious piety and purpose. He is meticulous, especially in bringing his rivals to book, but is not a visionary and seems hackneyed, even straitjacketed, in his thinking. Of late, he has adopted a deliberately insulting anti-India tone."

A Study in Contrasts

All this is in sharp contrast to his mentor and immediate predecessor, General Qamar Javed Bajwa, the army chief between 2016 and 2022. Bajwa was a powerful behind-the-scenes player in Pakistani politics when the mercurial Imran was PM and asserted the military's dominance over public policy. It was under his tenure that the Pulwama attacks were authorised, and India responded with air force strikes on terror camps inside Pakistani territory. The first such air attack by India since the 1971 war, it was a move that set a new paradigm of deterrence, signalling to Pakistan that such cross-border terror attacks would not go unpunished.

However, toward the end of his tenure, Bajwa called for a dramatic shift in Pakistan's focus from geopolitics to geoeconomics, arguing that his country must put its own house in order economically by pursuing regional connectivity, trade and development partnerships, even with India. As a sign of his earnestness, he entered into a ceasefire agreement on the LoC in February 2021, which held for four years before Munir engineered the Pahalgam massacre and destroyed the tenuous truce. As Ajay Bisaria, a former Indian High Commissioner to Pakistan, explains, "Bajwa was cut from a different cloth because he believed that the whole jihadi complex that the army had created had stopped serving Pakistan well and wanted to shift the focus to economic development. He wanted changes, but was a gradualist. Meanwhile, the marriage between him and Imran soured and he lost his nerve."

Discarding the Bajwa doctrine, Munir's vision of Pakistan is of a 'hard state', one that is strong and unyielding against both internal and external threats and ever ready for a robust military response. Internally, Banerjee says, Munir unsparingly quashed dissent in the army and across the political spectrum. Externally, he adopted a tough, no-nonsense approach,